

A Shared Vision for the Future

Rare and Complex Epilepsies in Australia

Developmental and Epileptic Encephalopathies (DEEs) are severe, genetically driven neurodevelopmental disorders. Epilepsy is only one feature of this complex, multi-system and lifelong condition. Treating DEEs as a subset of epilepsy understates their impact and produces the wrong system response — they require coordinated action across health, disability, education, research and social systems. Throughout this Report, DEEs are also referred to as Rare and Complex Epilepsies, a term that reflects the severity and breadth of these conditions rather than narrowing them to a clinical label.

Australia does not lack expertise. It lacks the national mechanisms to align and deploy it.

Strengths in clinical care, diagnostics, research, disability, education, policy and advocacy are disconnected. Families pay the price for that fragmentation through delayed diagnosis, inconsistent multidisciplinary care, disability and education systems that cannot respond to complexity, and inequitable access to emerging precision therapies. These are not isolated service gaps — they are the predictable consequences of a system without national leadership.

The current Senate Inquiry and heightened political attention create a time-limited window for reform. The DEE Roundtable 2026 brought together patient advocates, clinicians, researchers, policymakers, industry and other sector leaders to determine what must happen next. A clear mandate emerged: Australia must establish a national organisation with the authority, representation and capability to lead the sector.

55

attendees at the Roundtable

34

organisations represented

1 May 2026

Roundtable held in Brisbane

FIVE SYSTEMS, NO FORMAL COORDINATION BETWEEN THEM

Health

Disability

Education

Research

Social

THE SECTOR'S CHOSEN MECHANISM

The National Rare and Complex Epilepsies Collaborative is the sector's chosen mechanism for national coordination. It will bring stakeholders together to align Australia's fragmented ecosystem, agree shared priorities, inform policy and system reform, accelerate research translation, improve care and strengthen advocacy for equitable access to emerging therapies.

1 The Problem

Families are not falling through gaps in one system; they are falling through gaps in every system, and none of these systems can meet their needs in isolation.

National Coordination

The sector is fragmented, with duplication of effort and no mechanism to convene or coordinate stakeholders.

National Voice

The landscape lacks a recognised, authoritative voice to represent all stakeholders, particularly families.

2 Scope of the Challenge

1 in 590 Australian children are affected by a DEE. (Poke et al., 2022)

DEEs are the most severe group of epilepsies: lifelong conditions associated with developmental slowing or regression. Most are genetically driven — each individually rare but collectively common; management depends on the underlying cause.

3 Consequences of Fragmentation

“I feel like I’m constantly having to explain that it’s not just epilepsy, it’s intellectual disability, it’s language delay, it’s behavioural challenges.”

— parent, DEE Roundtable family consultation

WHERE FRAGMENTATION IS FELT

Recognition Beyond Epilepsy

Care narrows to seizure control; developmental, behavioural and disability needs are obscured.

Coordinated Lifelong Support

Repeated crises, burnout and retelling their story to professionals who do not communicate.

Diagnosis, Treatment and Research

Access varies by state; adults and late-onset presentations are particularly disadvantaged.

Integrated Systems

NDIS pathways are slow and unpredictable; schools lack condition-specific knowledge.

Research Translation

World-class capability, but duplicated effort and limited visibility of who is doing what.

“This Report is not a record of discussion. It captures the sector consensus to move from fragmented goodwill to coordinated national delivery.”

4 Shared Vision

The Collaborative will bring together patient groups, clinicians, researchers, governments and advocacy organisations within a nationally coordinated, equitable and person-centred Rare and Complex Epilepsies ecosystem.

People & Families

A coordinated, navigable system centred on their needs across the lifespan.

Clinicians

Connected specialist networks and a nationally consistent model of care.

Researchers

A connected, data-enabled national research ecosystem.

Industry Partners

An attractive environment for responsible research and investment.

Policymakers

A clear national understanding informing policy, funding and service design.

Advocates

Aligned priorities and a stronger national voice.

5 Sector Consensus

Strong sector-wide agreement has emerged: to establish an independent national organisation with multi-stakeholder governance that provides leadership and representation for the sector. Its roles should include:

Leadership and coordination across the Rare and Complex Epilepsies landscape

Policy and systems engagement, including structured government liaison

Development of national standards of care, diagnostic pathways and models of practice

Coordination of research and data, including national registries and harmonised coding

7 Next Phase

The consultation phase has established the basis for action. The next phase is to establish the Collaborative and bring stakeholders together to determine how the Roundtable priorities are taken forward. Funding is an immediate strategic priority.

IMMEDIATE PRIORITIES

Governance

Stakeholder
engagement

Funding

Government
engagement

The Committee will use the Senate Inquiry and the lead-up to the 2027 Federal Election to seek commitments to national recognition, establishment funding and government partnership.

Contact

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